

ANI

reached its crescendo with a mammoth rally in central Kolkata on July 16. With chief minister Mamata Banerjee and TMC scion Abhishek Banerjee on the podium, full-throated commitment to the cause was guaranteed. The BJP, Mamata alleged, was trying to reduce Bengalis to the status of 'infiltrators' in their own country. In pouring rain, she brought the teeming crowds to boiling point, claiming the Centre had secretly instructed BJP-ruled states to arrest and deport Bengali-speaking individuals, often without cause. "Why are you torturing Bengalis? People are being arrested even after showing documents. What was their fault? Just speaking in Bengali?" she demanded. The TMC has not been alone in raising the alarm. On July 15, the CPI(M), too, organised a march to show solidarity with Bengali-speaking migrants.

The sense of persecution is reinforced by some well-publicised cases. In Delhi's Jai Hind Colony in Vasant Kunj, home to hundreds of Bengali-speaking daily wage workers, TMC MPs and leaders, including Sagarika Ghose, Saket Gokhale, Dola Sen and Sukhendu Sekhar Roy, joined sit-in protests after reports emerged that residents with valid Aadhaar and voter ID cards were being branded 'illegal', and then denied basic amenities like power and water. Similar targeting was reported from Maharashtra, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Assam.

One case involved Nizamuddin Sheikh, a 34-year-old mason from Murshidabad's Hariharpara. Picked up by the Mumbai police on June 10 despite having proper identification, he was flown to Tripura and allegedly pushed across the Bangladesh border by the Border Security Force. "They beat us with lathis and boots," Nizamuddin said after his return. "We had no phones, no money, only fear." Once he contacted the Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB), he was eventually repatriated via Cooch Behar on June 17. Others such as Minarul Sheikh from Murshidabad, Mostafa Kamal Sheikh from Bardhaman, and Fazel and Taslima Mandal from North 24 Parganas were also reportedly deported, and later brought back through state intervention. Acting on a petition regarding six detainees from Birbhum's Pikor village allegedly deported to Bangladesh, the Calcutta High Court on July 11 asked the Union home ministry to submit a detailed explanation of its deportation drive.

"It's unconstitutional. The BSF did not contact the state before deporting Indian citizens," says Samirul Islam, TMC Rajya Sabha MP and chairperson of the West Bengal Migrant Welfare Board. Some 2.2



**"BENGALIS ARE BEING ARRESTED EVEN AFTER SHOWING DOCUMENTS. WHAT WAS THEIR FAULT? JUST SPEAKING IN BENGALI?"**

**MAMATA BANERJEE**
*Chief Minister, West Bengal*

## PARRY AND RIPOSTE

***Language, identity, points and counterpoints...the arguments of the main political adversaries in Bengal***

### TMC

- **Alleges Bengali-speaking migrant workers are being detained and deported from BJP-ruled states despite having valid documents**
- **Bengal hosts over 15 million migrants; TMC asks why Bengali migrants are not treated with dignity**
- **Accuses BJP-governed states of violating federal principles, citizens' rights**
- **Frames its campaign as a defence of 'Bangaliyana'—a cultural-linguistic identity beyond religion—against right-wing Hindutva**

### BJP

- **Argues actions are aimed at only Rohingya or Bangladeshi infiltrators**
- **Claims population spike in West Bengal's border areas is due to illegal immigration; calls for revision of voter rolls**
- **Accuses TMC of fuelling linguistic paranoia for political gain**
- **Says unemployment in Bengal is the root cause of mass migration to other states, which the TMC is now deflecting through identity politics**